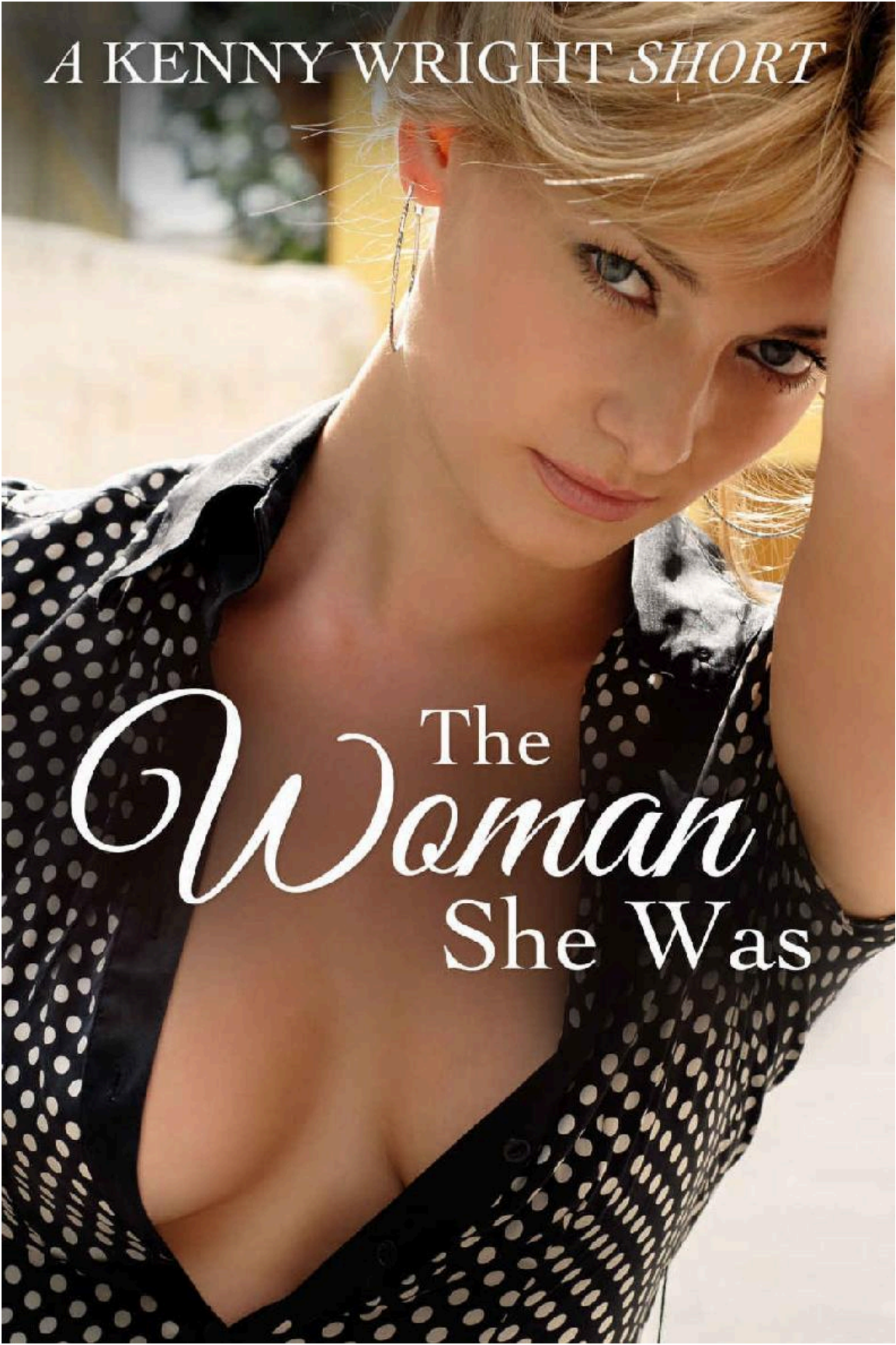


A KENNY WRIGHT SHORT

The
Woman
She Was



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First digital edition electronically published by KW Publishing,

June 2015

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1.

[Chris]: We just boarded. I'll see you in a few hours, honey.

[Avery]: Yay!

I shut my phone down and sat back in my seat. I pictured my wife on the other end of the line, smiling as she sent me the message. She was at the hospital now, working her shift in the ER, but she was sexy, even in her scrubs. She usually wore her long, honey blond hair in a messy bun when she was working, and I always looked forward to that moment when she'd shake it down. If we were alone, that motion was usually followed by her stripping out of her scrubs and revealing her tight little body—"

"This 16B?" a man asked, drawing me out of my thoughts.

"This is," I said.

The guy was about my age, good looking in a rough-around-the-edges kind of way. He had a shaved head, a close-cropped beard of light brown hair, and striking blue eyes. I could see a tattoo etched along his neck, the ink faded, the pattern unrecognizable as it disappeared beneath his t-shirt.

“Hey, I’m Bryce,” he said once he’d settled his bags. *Bryce*. It was an unusual name—unusual enough that it stirred a memory, but I couldn’t quite place it.

“Chris.”

We went about our own things as the flight attendants walked us through the safety measures and the plane taxied to the runway. Once we were in the air, though, with three long hours ahead of us, Bryce broke the ice.

“Business trip?”

“Yeah. Out in Seattle. It’s been a long day.”

“Sounds it.”

Our flight attendant came by, pushing a refreshment cart to the front of the plane. She was a cute blonde who reminded me a little of Avery, although Avery had a more natural prettiness to her than the made-up flight attendant. Didn’t stop me from watching her ass as she moved down the aisle. The trip had only been a week, but I felt so sex starved.

“Yeah, she’s pretty hot, isn’t she?” Bryce said beside me. “Love a tight ass. It may be the most important characteristic of a woman for me.”

“She’s not bad,” I said politely.

He made a show of looking around. “Oh, sorry, didn’t realize your wife was here. Which is she?”

I laughed, but more out of reflex than because of anything funny. “No, she’s not here. And actually, I was thinking that our flight attendant kind of reminded me of my wife.”

“So you think your wife’s just *not bad*? See, this is why I’m never getting tied down.”

I felt defensive. “No, my wife’s beautiful. More than her. It’s the makeup.”

Bryce screwed up his face. “You don’t like makeup?”

I groaned. This was going to be a long flight.

Bryce seemed to detect my frustration and grinned. “I’m just fucking with you, man. I know what you’re saying. The stewardess is a bit trampy, right? Bet she’s got a tat on her lower back, what do you think?”

We watched her start taking drink orders at the front of the plane. She had to bend down to

retrieve some Diet Cokes from the lower drawer and her dress stretched tightly across her nice ass.

“No panty lines, either. That not your thing, either? You like the VPLs?”

I had to laugh at his forwardness. It was almost refreshing after the stuffy meetings I’d been stuck in all week. But just almost.

“No, I appreciate her attention to that detail.”

Bryce laughed. “I like you, Chris. Let me guess, you’re an English professor.”

“Close. I’m a market analyst. I give small banks investment advice.”

“Cool.” He didn’t sound condescending, although I felt a little self-conscious about it. In Bryce’s eyes, I felt very uncool, despite what he said, so I tried opening up a little.

“I guess it’s kind of like teaching, although teaching is probably a lot less stressful.”

Bryce laughed gruffly. “But a lot more boring. You travel a lot for that gig?”

“Starting this trip, yeah. Didn’t used to, but I got promoted, so now I’m on the road.”

He looked at my ring. “What does wifey say about that?”

“She’s not thrilled, but it’s good for the career, so, you know....”

“I don’t, actually. I have no fucking clue.” He held up his left hand, showing that he had no ring on it. Instead, he had letters tattooed across the backs of his fingers—R-O-C-K.

First thing I thought was, *How cliché*. Second thing I thought was, *I know this guy!* Or, knew of him. And in the craziest way possible. He was Avery’s boyfriend back in college. I remember finding that photo of the two of them. She wore a Brown University hoodie, her head resting on his shoulder.

He had his fists thrust at the camera, P-U-N-K R-O-C-K tattooed across the backs of his fingers. I knew next to nothing about him other than that they’d dated and that she called it her *bad boy* phase.

“So you live in Philly?” I hope I sounded casual enough.

Avery and I barely talked about our pasts. At first, I thought I didn’t want to know. What was past was past and all that. But as time went on, I grew more curious—especially about this whole bad boy thing. The thought of what my wife might have done back with other guys turned me on. I started fantasizing about it, but by that time I realized that I had the fantasy, it felt too late to bring up the past.

So here was my chance to learn something without having to raise it directly.

“I’m sorry, what was that?” I asked when I realized that I had no clue what he’d just said. I added,

“Distracted.”

Bryce looked over his shoulder, just as our flight attendant passed by again. He grinned. "I thought that she wasn't your type."

"Well...."

"It's cool, man. We're casual acquaintances here. We probably won't ever see each other again."

I wasn't so sure about that, based on the single degree of separation I'd just discovered, but I kept the thought to myself. He went on, oblivious. "You can admit that you like a little trampiness. I won't judge. Who doesn't like the thought of a wild girl?"

He was right, of course. I was drawn to women with more girl-next-door qualities, but in the porn I watched, all the girls were made-up and glamorous.

Bryce pressed. "Come on, man, don't tell me that the thought of your wife blowing out her hair and wiggling into a slinky cocktail dress isn't hot."

That particular insight hit closer to home than he realized. Maybe because of porn, whenever I fantasized about Avery hooking up with other guys, she looked more like our flight attendant than *Avery*.

"Yeah, sure I do," I said. "But she's not like that."

Bryce laughed. "You act as though it has to be either/or. Like women are that simple."

"Fair." I was underestimating him, maybe because of the bluntness, or his punk rock tattoo, but he went to Brown with Avery, which meant that he wasn't an idiot. That got me thinking about Avery.

Had I oversimplified her, too?

Bryce went on. "But I got you. Most girls do kind of fall into one camp or the other. Good girls and bad girls, right?"

I wasn't sure if he was baiting me or not, so I nodded noncommittally.

He leaned in. “But the hottest chicks are the ones that look like good girls, but behave like the dirty ones, am I right?”

That cut deep. Avery was a sweetheart, quick to offer a kind remark or a shoulder for a friend.

We fostered dogs, and she always cried when they went to new homes. But in the bedroom, she did things that blew my mind. She knew how to fuck, and as I looked over at my new traveling companion, I began to wonder if he had something to do with it.

“What can I get you?” Our flight attendant had returned. I’d written her off too quickly, too. She was very pretty, playing her part well with a scarf tied around her slender neck and her dark blue dress just snug enough to hint at her charms.

She raised an eyebrow at me. “Something to drink?”

“Oh, sorry.” I flushed. “Cranberry juice, please.”

She wrote something down and turned her attention to Bryce.

He gave her a winning smile. “I’ll take a Budweiser.”

“That’ll be five.”

When he passed his card to her, I couldn’t help but notice...something happen between them. He was flirting, and right in front of me!

“Thank you, Mr. King,” she said with a dimpled smile.

“Call me Bryce, Ms...?”

“Jenny.” She tucked a strand of hair over her ear and smiled again before moving on to the next row.

Bryce gave me a significant look. I just shook my head.

“So what do you do, Bryce? Sales.”

Bryce had a barking, gruff laugh. “I’m a masseuse.”

Okay, I wasn’t expecting that. I looked again at his hands. “Really?”

“Truly. And before you think it—because I know you’re not going to ask—yes, I sometimes give *happy endings*. Only to women though, and no, they’re not always hot.” He chuckled. “But the ones that are get a particularly happy ending.”

“You’re certainly...open.”

Bryce laughed again. “Life’s too short to be anything but. Gets me in trouble sometimes, but fuck all that.”

We receded into our own worlds for a bit after that. I pulled out my Kindle. He played some games on his phone. About an hour into the flight, he excused himself to go to the bathroom. It was late—pushing ten o’clock—and most of the passengers were dozing.

I thought nothing of it until he came back, nearly ten minutes later.

“Long line?” I asked as he settled back into his seat.

“No line at all,” he said with a grin. He let the statement linger before adding, “I was right. She’s got a tat on her lower back. A fucking butterfly, if you’d believe that. And I don’t think that was her first time getting dirty in the airplane bathroom.”

I blinked, finally getting what he was saying. “You fucked the flight attendant?”

“Jenny,” he said. “And yes I did. She’s a little spitfire.”

I shook my head, hardly believing it. I mean, I did believe it, but it still didn’t seem real. Did that kind of thing really happen?

“It wasn’t the best lay, but I’ve never done it in a plane. And besides, she reminds me of an ex

back in school.”

“Yeah? She have a tattoo on her lower back, too?”

“Nah, they just kind of look the same. Same blond hair. Same upturned nose and blue eyes.” He lowered his voice. “Same bald snatch.”

Avery was blond, had a cute, pert little nose, and she did keep herself smooth, ever since I’d known her. Her eyes were green, not blue, although in certain light they could look blue. I forced myself to sound as casual as possible. “So was this ex a good girl on the outside, dirty on the inside?”

Bryce grinned. “That’s my type, yeah. And yes, she sure was a dirty one.”

The fist that I’d imagined around my heart cranked down. For a moment, my vision did that narrowing thing, the sides going fuzzy and dark.

“You okay?” he asked. “You look pretty white.”

I blinked, reached for my cup of cranberry juice, and finished it. “Sorry, I hate flying.”

Bryce laughed. “Says the banking consultant.”

“Hey, I’m new to this.” It was much easier to talk about my fear of flying than the implications of what he was saying. But I couldn’t *not* talk about those implications. I felt the need as surely as an alcoholic. “So what made her so dirty?”

His smile was a personal one, the kind reserved for recalling a particularly happy memory. Only that memory was my wife, and that smile sent a shiver through me. “Well, to really understand her, you need some background. She was hot, of course, but in a good girl way. Good parents always ruin the best of them. Blonde, long legs, great ass, and a pair of tits just the perfect size for her athletic body. She was perfect. And best of all? She barely knew it.”

The Avery that I’d met after college knew she was sexy, so that didn’t fit. Her parents had also divorced when she was in high school, after her dad

cheated on her mom, so I wouldn't call them

“good parents.” But all the rest fit. The physical description was about perfect.

He continued, oblivious to my unease. “She was also a real fucking challenge. I had to chase her.

And I did, too. I think she was the first girl that hadn't let me fuck her on the first date that I still wanted to go on a second date with. Usually, that's my litmus test: no sex on the first date means no potential.”

“I take it your theory was wrong?”

“Oh yeah.”

My stomach squirmed at his confident, grinning reply. “So it was worth pursuing her?”

“Yeah. So worth it that I went exclusive with her and shit. Hell, I thought I wanted to marry her.

Even asked her.”

Wow, I didn't know that. “She turn you down?”

Bryce nodded. “She said she had fun with me, but that she wasn't in love with me. Crazy, isn't it?

The only girl I ever fell for and she was just there for a good time.”

“Does that make you bitter?”

“Nah.” He waved his hand, and I shook my head. I'd never known someone so blasé. This guy was as chill as it got. I could see what women saw in him. “She was right, of course. I'm not husband material and that chick needed someone solid. We had our fun, though.”

“Like what?” I couldn't help myself.

“When we first started dating, she’d never gone down on a guy. By the time we broke up, she was the best I’d had.”

I could attest to that. Avery gave fantastic head, although it had been a little while since I’d gotten any.

Bryce went on. “I mean, the girl loved it. So much so that I had to invite a friend over from time to time because I couldn’t keep up.”

It felt like a gut punch. Really? Avery liked giving blow jobs so much that she did it for this guy’s friends? Then, the more rational side of me wondered if a) was he exaggerating, or b) was he even talking about my wife.

“You let her do that with other guys?” I asked.

Bryce shrugged. “Sure. I’m not a possessive guy. It was actually pretty fun to watch her play. She had such a fantastic little body. It was pretty awesome watching her ride someone, even if it wasn’t me.”

Jesus. The curse hissed through my brain. She’d fucked other guys, too? Now I knew that this couldn’t be my wife. Casual sex wasn’t a thing she believed in. I still remember the long month she’d made me wait.

Still, whoever he was talking about sounded sexy. “Did that happen often?”

Bryce caught on to my curiosity. “I don’t know about often. Maybe a couple times a month? It was always pretty spontaneous though. One time, for example, we were at this bar on campus, right?

We were looking to score some blow—”

“Blow?”

“You know.” He reached up and tweaked his nose.

A pit opened up in my stomach and nearly swallowed me whole. No. He wasn’t going there—

“Lot of that going around school in those days. We liked to party, and coke always made her horny.”

The revelation felt like a gut bomb. My wife doing drugs? Cocaine?! There was just no way.

“We met up with a buddy of mine, Reggie, who was there with his girlfriend. He’d been with Avie before—”

“Avie?” The air inside the plane grew thinner.

Misinterpreting my question, he nodded. “Yeah, he’d come over once before and Avie blew him, but that was before he was going with this new girl.” I tried to calm myself. Maybe even did, but Jesus.... “Anyway, I suggested we all go back to my place and party. Before we knew it, my buddy’s girl is all over mine. They’re making out, fingering each other. Reggie and I just sat back and watched the show. It was awesome, dude. These two chicks almost looked like sisters, you know?

Fucking hot. Reg fucked Avie while she went down on his girlfriend, who was blowing me. Best night of my life, and that’s saying something.”

I was about as stunned as I’ve ever been in my life. So many revelations. Too many to count. I had no words. I couldn’t even begin to process it. Drugs. Group sex. Lesbian sex?!

So all I could say was, “Wow.”

“I know, right?”

“Did she hook up with other girls after that?”

“A few. She said she enjoyed it, but she’d rather just get fucked, so we mostly stuck to other guys.”

“And she wasn’t interested in settling down with you?”

“Nah, like I said, she had her own thing going. Graduated at the top of her class, poli sci. Think she went and got her MBA or some shit. Lost track of

her after that.”

That part wasn’t right. Avery was a bio major and went on to medical school, but maybe he was just remembering wrong. It was a while ago.

It was easier to imagine that he was talking about some other blonde whose name with a nickname of Avie, as insanely unlikely as that was. Easier, but a bit too hard to believe.

“You sure about the MBA?”

“Nope. Like I said, I was out of her life after that. But it’s for the best. Wearing suits, studying in groups and shit. Schmoozing. I’m not really cut out for a life like that.”

He kept pressing the business school thing, which made it a little easier to believe that Avie was actually not Avery, but I still couldn’t not believe it. “Sounds like she’s not cut out for that life, either.”

He chuckled. “Nah. I was just her excuse to be a bad girl before she settled down.”

Bad girl... Bad boy period... *Stop it.*

“Isn’t that kind of cliché?” I asked.

“Sure, but I see it all the time. There’s a lot of truth in a cliché.”

I thought of Avery, checking on patients in her scrubs, a stethoscope draped around her neck. Did she get the bad girl out of her system? Can someone really give that up, once it’s there?

“Have you reached out to her?” I wish that I could have taken that question back. It was a dangerous one that had no good answer. He said *yes* and I’d get nervous. He said *no* and I’d be disappointed, as fucked up as that was.

“Yeah.”

Ka-fucking-thunk.

“I emailed her back when I knew I was moving into the area.” My stomach flopped. Avery hadn’t mentioned that before. “She’s married now, just like I figured.”

“Bitter?”

“Man, you keep asking that. Like I said, that’s what she always wanted. It’s the life she deserves, too, so I’m happy for her.” He looked at my ring.

“You’re in the same boat. You must know what I’m talking about.”

I don’t know why I said this next thing because it wasn’t even true. But it felt like the thing to say to dig deeper into this side of Avery that I didn’t know existed. “Well, sure, but married life isn’t about group sex and recreational drug use. It’s not as exciting as that.”

Bryce laughed. “Well, I’m not saying she’s excited. I’m saying she’s happy. There’s a difference.

Besides, I don’t think the two are mutually exclusive, even in a marriage.”

What was he saying? I knew the obvious one, but conveniently ignored it. “Like swinging?” I said instead.

Bryce laughed again, rubbing his chin. “I suppose that’s an option for some couples. And I’ve known a few to go that route. Hell, I probably would have been one of them if I ever got hitched.”

“So what then?”

Bryce was suddenly coy. “I probably shouldn’t tell a happily married man such as yourself. You might not like the answer.”

“Cheating?” Saying it tasted like sawdust in my mouth.

“A fling. Nothing is quite as exciting. Or so I’ve heard.”

“I don’t think I could do that,” I said.

Bryce shrugged. “Then it’s a good thing I’m not into dudes.”

“So what about this old girlfriend of yours? Think that’s what she’s looking for?”

“I couldn’t say.”

A weight left my shoulders, a weight I hadn’t realized was there until it was gone.

“But I’m meeting her for drinks next Friday, so I’ll know after that.”

It washed over me like nothing. Numb. Anesthetized. I just sat there and nodded. “Nicely done.”

I was back to talking about her like she wasn’t my wife. Only I knew that I was.

We talked about other stuff after that. I was tempted to keep digging, keep learning about this woman who I thought I knew but didn’t at all. But I’d touched the hot stove and couldn’t build up the courage to do it again.

By the time the plane landed, I wanted to never see him again. Part of me actually thought that if I believed that enough, maybe Avery wouldn’t see him again either. But even if she did, she wasn’t going to actually do anything, right?

We parted at the terminal exit. He had everything he needed in his carry-on, a black duffle that wasn’t even filled. I had baggage to claim.

“It’s nice to meet you,” I said.

“You too, man. Good luck with your wife.”

“What?” For one fleeting moment, I thought it was a threat.

“You said your wife wasn’t crazy about your new, traveling job.”

“Oh, right.”

“But hey, makes coming home that much better, right? Take care, man.”

“You, too.”

And with that, he walked out the door to the line of taxis. I just stood there for the longest moment as travelers flowed past me and the airport intercom chimed away. I was almost home, but I wasn’t sure it would feel like it.

2.

Eventually, someone jostled me and I snapped out of my trance—at least enough to move out of the doors. I checked the baggage claim belt and wandered in that direction like a balloon pushed along by a breeze.

Thing was, learning about Avery’s past—if that really was Avery that Bryce had been talking about—was hot. Like, really hot. I knew that she had a good amount of experience before me, and I always liked that, even if we never talked about it. In fact, the not talking was part of what made it exciting. If I didn’t know what secrets she had, I was free to imagine anything, yet could always fall back on the fact that I really didn’t know when those creeping feelings of insecurity got too much.

Now I knew—or thought I knew. She’d had threesomes. She’d experimented with other women.

She’d done recreational drugs that I only ever associated with after school specials and celebrities like Lindsay Lohan. Now that I knew, the safety net was gone.

But it was still hot.

The other part of my fantasy was something that I’d never intended to be anything more than a fantasy—to watch Avery with another man. Whenever I thought about it, I was almost as ashamed as I was excited. Almost. But the level of excitement that particular vision delivered hit crazy levels.

In my dreams, I’d watch from the closet as another man took my wife. He’d pin her to the wall, pick her up, and fuck her until she screamed. I imagined every detail of her face—sweat gathering around her brow and clumping in

her hair, her eyes shut, her teeth clenched as she came. That image always did it for me. Always got me hard.

I was hard as I called it to mind in the airport. And in one week, it could be real. That thought struck like a lightning bolt. It burned. It was disorienting. And yet, I'd never been left so electrified.

Carousel 2 was my destination, and despite the fact that it felt like hours since I'd deboarded, our luggage was just coming off the belt.

I looked around, recognizing some of the people in the group. There was the kind faced grandfather. The girls on the high school soccer trip. The young family with the three kids. It was weird recognizing them, like seeing people in real life that you'd only ever dreamt about. I looked at them. They looked at me. Had they heard my conversation with Bryce? Did they know that he was going to meet up with my wife to fuck her?

Hands covered my eyes. A warm, soft body pressed up behind me as a familiar scent filled my nose, fresh and fruity.

"Surprise," a woman whispered into my ear.

"Avery?"

I turned, and there she was. My wife. My sweet, beautiful wife. She was smiling, from her mouth to her green, green eyes—green, not blue. Dimples formed in her cheeks. It was her. Not a dream. Not a fantasy.

"Last I checked, that was my name."

"What are you doing here?"

She tipped her head to one side. "Aw, I love you too."

I laughed. "I love you, too."

"I switched shifts with Cady. I wanted to surprise you."

“I’m surprised!” Then, realizing how ungracious I was sounding, I added, “In a good way.” That didn’t sound much better. “Sorry, I’m just tired. Long flight.”

Avery’s eyes sparkled. “Hope you’re not *too* tired....”

I looked at her, filled with promise, and saw a flash of Bryce’s Avery. My heart jumped. My boxers tightened. If she’d brush her hand across my pants, she would have felt my erection.

I shied back, but that only drew attention to it. She stepped close enough that her hip rested against my crotch. Her smile widened. “Looks like something’s not too tired.”

“I....”

She looked over my shoulder. “Oh, honey, I think that’s your bag.”

*

Avery looked like the same woman I’d kissed goodbye last week. She was still casually beautiful, dressed down in a loose summer dress and a pair of TOMS. She wore a cardigan as usual when she was inside despite the summer humidity outside. Her blond hair was tied back in a jaunty ponytail, just like it was nine times out of ten.

But she wasn’t the same. I looked at her sweet, smiling face and saw the woman she was with Bryce. I imagined her sucking his cock. Thought of her sucking off Bryce’s friends. Pictured her sitting at the computer, her heart racing as she reconnected with Bryce over email or Facebook or whatever.

The last thought struck particularly hard. Panic edged in around me. I controlled my breathing to keep it at bay.

“Got it,” Avery said. She extended the handle of my bag and started rolling it toward the garage.

“What’s in here? Did anyone tell you that you pack like a woman?”

“I believe you did, dear. About five times before I left.”

Avery laughed. “Oh, right. Now I remember. Well, make that six then.”

“I’m still trying to figure out this traveling thing,” I said. “Now I know that I don’t need twice as many pairs of socks as the days that I’ll be there. And that I only really need two suits.”

We stopped at the elevator, and Avery took my hand in hers. “Next thing you’ll know, you’ll be just like George Clooney in *Up in the Air*.”

“You’d like that, huh?” I teased. Avery had an unapologetic crush on George Clooney.

“Don’t be silly, Chris, I like the way you look just fine. If I wanted George Clooney, I’d go after him myself.” I laughed because I was supposed to, but something about the statement unsettled me.

“I missed you,” I said. I’d said the words before, of course. We say those things all the time. But I felt the weight of the words this time. Felt it deep. I *missed* her. How was I going to make these trips again and again?

Avery heard the poignancy, too. She turned to look at me and smiled brightly. “I missed you, too.”

We loaded up the car. “So besides missing me, how did the trip go?”

“Busy. Successful.”

“Did you get to see any of Seattle?”

“Besides the hotel and the office? I saw a few things out the taxi window to and from.”

“My husband, the work-a-holic.”

“That’s kind of like the pot calling the kettle black, don’t you think?”

Avery laughed, turning the car on. “Hey, I’m here, aren’t I?”

“Yeah, you are.” I leaned over and kissed her neck as she navigated through the parking garage.

Avery giggled. “Calm down there, champ. Twenty more minutes before home.”

That conversation with Bryce had me thinking about the dirtier version of Avery. Coupled with a week without sex and I wasn’t thinking completely rationally.

I ran my hand up the inside of her thigh. Her skin was so smooth. “Too long.”

She glanced at me as she pulled into the exit booth. I slid my hand higher. She paid, doing her best to ignore me.

“Maybe next time, I could meet you out there at the end. We could explore the city together.”

Something about the way she was deliberately ignoring my hand made me think of her sexual history, and how I’d known none of it. It made me even more impatient to have her right then and there.

“Yeah, that would be fun.” I could feel her heat against my fingertips, and as she pulled out of the airport, I pressed firmly against her silky panties.

She gunned it, accelerating fast enough to press me into my seat.

It didn’t dissuade me. I found her pussy again. She laughed, and when she spoke, her voice was tight. “I do kind of like this, though.”

“This?” I asked. She seemed to grow even hotter, and I could feel her moisture beneath her thin panties. I walked my fingers up her slit and over the top of her underwear.

“Yeah. Like how you can’t even wait for us to get— *home*.... ”

I teased down the front of her pussy. Her smooth pussy reminded me of Bryce all over again

— *same bald snatch*—and a confused heat welled up inside me again. I pressed my fingers into her, drawing a gasp. She was wet.

Avery took a deep breath and focused on the road in front of her. I leaned over and kissed her neck. “Did you miss me?” I asked.

“Uh huh....”

“Were you a good girl?” I don’t know why I asked it—she didn’t know about my fantasy—yet out it came.

“Maybe....” She gasped. My heart skipped.

“Maybe?” My imagination jumped to her in bed with another man—a fellow doctor at work, maybe—as implausible as it was. My lungs grew tight. My cock buzzed.

“The showerhead may have gotten an extra workout.” Her laugh turned into a moan.

Disappointment and relief, why did I feel them both?

“And you? Were you good, Chris?”

“Of course.” We pulled off the highway, then detoured off of Lincoln Drive onto School House Lane—not our usual route home. I asked, “Where are we going?”

“I don’t know,” Avery said. “Somewhere that I can fuck you.”

It was close to midnight and most places were closed up. She drove us into an empty parking lot of Philadelphia University. Pulling into a spot about as secluded as it got for the heart of the city, she unbuckled her seatbelt and crawled into my lap.

“It’s been awhile since we’ve done it in the car,” she said.

Her statement hit me harder than she probably intended. We’d *never* done it in the car, and yet she seemed to know exactly what she was doing. I rolled

the seat as far back as it went as she slipped out of her panties.

“Hurry, before security comes,” she said. The fear of being caught motivated me more. I helped her open my pants, then guided her onto my cock.

“I so missed this,” she moaned.

I took hold of her ass in my hands, round and wonderfully familiar. How many men had felt it?

We’d never had that discussion, as crazy as that was. We never talked about our numbers. Now I wanted to know.

I just couldn’t ask. Whatever had held me back all these years from asking was a hard thing to kick. So I put all my energy into fucking her. I squeezed her ass, shutting my eyes, the dirty things

she’d done filling the darkness. I imagined her in this same position, only she was astride Bryce’s lap, not mine, and in the driver’s seat was a second man. She was twisted over him, sucking his cock as she rode Bryce to a screaming orgasm.

“Ah, you feel huge,” Avery moaned.

I added that line to the scene, too. *Bryce, you feel huge.*

“Fuck me,” she hissed.

Fuck me, Bryce. You like watching me suck your friend off?

“Yes,” I gasped.

“Oh, God, baby, I’m close.” Her eyes were shut. Her mind on the feeling of me inside her. Or was she thinking about someone else? Someone she’d been chatting with online? An old flame?

“Me...too....”

Avery in the airplane lav dressed as a flight attendant, pinned against the mirror as Bryce drove his thick cock into her from behind.

Avery's moans strained through the car. Through the tiny bathroom. Through my fantasy. I squeezed her ass harder, lifting her up and down my length. "Yes!"

Avery meeting Bryce next week. Laughing at his jokes. Kissing him back when he kissed her.

I thrust up into her. Harder and harder. I was sweating. My arms burned from the strain. I dug deep. Kept pushing.

Avery letting herself be pulled out to her car—this car—where the kissing continued. Where hands wandered, pants unzipped. Where she climbed into Bryce's lap and speared herself on his cock.

Avery's cries hit a fevered pitch. I couldn't hold back. Couldn't stop the fantasy from overwhelming. "Oh, Avery! Oh!"

She joined me, clutching my head and bowing forward, her whole body shaking with her orgasm. We held each other through the quaking climax, mutual, yet so fucking not. For one confusing moment, I thought she'd actually done it with Bryce, that *I* had been the fantasy and Bryce the reality.

"Wow," she said when she finally found a voice to speak. The windows of her car were fogged up. Our heavy breathing filled the space.

"Missed you."

"So what was that?" She didn't sound like she was upset, just winded. She pushed her damp bangs out of her face.

The orgasm temporarily sated the forbidden fantasy in me, leaving me spent and slightly ashamed of myself. "That was me saying *hello*."

Avery laughed, and all my worries, all my shame, bled away. "Well, I missed you, too, hon."

She kissed me, and my wife was back. The woman who'd just celebrated her thirtieth. The girl with the smirky smile and the pert little nose. I held her close. Maybe I was wrong. Maybe everything was some huge coincidence—that Bryce's *Avie* wasn't my Avery.

3.

Thing was, I couldn't really believe that. Too many of the things that Bryce had said rang true—his description of her, her personality, or that her name for her was fucking "Avie." Even if Avie wasn't Avery, I knew that he really did date Avery. I had photographic evidence of that. And I also knew the kind of guy Bryce was, and the kind of girls he dated.

I tried to recall my conversation with Avery after I'd found the photo. *Oh, he's just a guy I dated back in college.* She didn't give a length of time they'd dated, or even when they'd dated in college. It could have been a couple weeks. It could have been six months. But they'd dated, which meant that they'd fucked, which meant that she had a story or two to tell that I didn't know about. Did she have a threesome with Bryce? Did she go down on another girl, or suck another guy off while getting nailed from behind?

But Bryce had asked her to marry him. Certainly that was worth noting beyond "just a guy I dated." Had she withheld that info? Or was she not Avie?

That night, I tossed and turned, all these questions tumbling through my head.

It all could have been written off as academic—in a very sexy way—had it not been for one thing: next Friday. This speculation had a time limit.

I could have just gone to Avery and asked. That probably was the wisest course of action to take.

Hey, you'll never guess who I sat next to on the plane.... Based on her reaction, maybe I could have even figured out whether she was Avie or not.

But that was the crazy thing. I didn't know that I wanted to know. Paradoxically, I wanted her to be, and I didn't. I wanted to think about her doing all those dirty things, and still be the sweet, girl-next-door that I'd met and married. That I intended to grow old with. And of course, if she was Avie, then there was also Friday.

Argh!

"Something wrong, Chris?" Avery asked.

I hadn't realized I'd actually spoken aloud. We were walking through the farmer's market on Winston Road. It was our Saturday morning tradition ever since we'd moved to Chestnut Hill.

"No. Just tired. Yesterday was long." It wasn't totally a lie. Yesterday *had* been long.

Avery linked her arm in mine and cozied up to me. "Nice end to the day, too."

We walked through the market some more, the smell of fresh produce and the morning sun loosening the tension I felt.

Of course, my tired, curious mind decided to work against me. "So you used to hook up in the car a lot?"

I felt Avery's eyes on me, but chose to focus on a guitar player singing, "You Are My Sunshine"

to a gathering of children.

"Not a lot," she said vaguely.

Finally, I looked at her. She was staring at me more inquisitive than anything else. In the morning light, her eyes were almost blue. "But sometimes?" I asked.

"Sometimes it was the only place to get privacy. You know, from parents. Roommates...."

Husbands, I thought with a chest-clenching shudder.

As she studied me, I did my best to look nonchalant. She saw right through me. “Why are you suddenly curious?”

Here was another chance to come clean about Bryce. Again, I chose not to.

So I went with a half truth. “I was thinking about what you said last night. It made me realize that there are aspects of you that still surprise me.”

“Oh, come on, everyone’s hooked up in the car at least once in their lives.”

I hadn’t been thinking about car sex, of course, but I couldn’t really say that. So I went vague.

“Oh, you know what I mean.”

As Avery contemplated my statement, I turned us away from the musician, plunging us back into the throng of the market. I held my breath, willing this conversation to end. For the length of three market stalls, I thought it had.

Avery guided us into a vendor selling plants. Long tables were lined with fresh herbs, flowers, potted vegetables ready for people’s gardens. There were other young urbanites browsing about, looking for the best fit for their patios and small backyards, but we had more space than on the crowded street.

I leaned over and smelled a sprout of cilantro. It smelled like soap to me, yet made my mouth water for guacamole. Funny how associations worked.

I felt Avery’s touch on my shoulder, felt her body press against mine. I thought she was bending down to smell the herb, too, when she stopped at my ear. “So you want to hear about my past?”

Yes! “Um, what makes you think that?”

“A hunch.” She looked around, making sure no one was looking, and snaked her hand between my legs. “Want to know a few other aspects of me

that will probably surprise you?”

My cock twitched enough that Avery could feel it through my shorts. She released me, stepping away with a satisfied smile.

“I’m busted,” I said sheepishly.

“Totally busted.”

I said, “You know what? I’m suddenly in the mood for brunch. And Bloody Marys.”

Avery giggled, placing a hand on my arm. “Sounds fun. Lead on.”

*

One day soon, we’d have kids, and we both knew that that day was fast approaching. We’d just celebrated Avery’s thirtieth. I was already thirty-three. Our time was coming.

But for now, we enjoyed the childless life. We both loved our jobs. We loved to travel. And we loved the freedom to have Bloody Marys—with a side of brunch—on a random Saturday morning.

We had money, freedom, and energy. Life would never again be so carefree.

It took me an entire Bloody Mary to get up the nerve to ask her about her past, and even then I couldn’t seem to ask directly about it.

“So what gave me away?”

I stirred my second Bloody Mary with a celery stalk as our server cleared away the ruin of our brunch. We were seated in a cafe along Germantown Avenue, the main drag through Chestnut Hill.

With its cobblestones and small boutiques, it was about as picture perfect as possible for us.

“Honestly?” Avery hesitated for half a second. “I’ve kind of suspected for a while now.”

“Really?” I could feel my brows go up.

Avery actually flushed a little and nodded. “Yeah. We’ve been together for what? Over six years now? I’ve picked up on a few things.”

“Like?” I was too surprised to be embarrassed.

“Oh, you know, just how you get this intense look whenever we talk about my college experiences. Or an old boyfriend.” She laughed. “You’re doing it now.”

I was and tried to laugh it off. “Sorry.”

“Don’t be sorry. Why would you be sorry?” She reached out and took my hands in hers. “Our sexuality is a crazy thing. We can’t always explain it.”

My heart tightened as I applied the same logic to her—or to Bryce’s Avie, anyway. “You’re right.”

“Of course I am,” she said with a satisfied nod.

“If you suspected, why didn’t you say something?”

Her face softened. “It’s not that easy. I mean, it’s kind of a big deal, and I learned that not every guy likes to think about their girlfriend’s past experiences. What if I was wrong? What would you have thought then?”

“Yeah, I see what you mean.”

“Think about it this way,” she said. “You’re the curious one, and it’s taken you over six years to ask.”

I nodded. “So you’ve had other boyfriends get...upset about your past?”

Avery had a wonderful laugh, especially when slightly drunk. It felt like sunshine on my face.

“It’s not like that, exactly. Just that some guys, you know, get a little jealous. I think it’s natural. I’m not particularly keen on thinking about your old girlfriends, either.”

“That makes sense. I was probably one of those guys before.”

“Yeah, you were,” she said with a laugh. “And you’re not now?”

I considered my reaction to Bryce. My jealousy had burned brightly when I thought he was talking about Avery—it still did when I really thought about it. But excitement overlaid it.

“Maybe a little, yeah,” I admitted.

“But not enough to contain your curiosity,” she stated.

“I guess not.”

I felt her foot brush against my ankle under the table. “So what do you want to know?”

Tell me about Bryce, I wanted to blurt. I needed to take a more roundabout approach. “Have you ever done it in any other public places? Besides the car, I mean?”

As soon as I said it, I looked around, my face burning with the possibility that someone had overheard. No one had.

“You mean like an empty lecture hall?” She pressed her foot against my ankle harder as she smiled. “Or the men’s bathroom of a bar?”

I stared across at Avery. She looked like the same woman I’d fallen in love with. She wore a cloth headband this morning to keep her pale hair back, making her look even more innocent. Hard to believe that she’d dated a guy like Bryce at all, even if she wasn’t Avie.

At my silence, she flashed her eyes. “Like that?”

I licked my lips, then regretted it. “Did you...did you really?”

“Mmm hmm.”

“Wow. In college?”

“Yes. I didn’t go to bars in high school.” She made it sound perfectly reasonable.

“Right.” I was having trouble regulating my breathing. “Are you messing with me?”

Avery giggled. “Maybe a little. But I’m not lying.” She leaned in. “Are you hard?”

“Yes.”

She smiled with delight. “What else do you want to know?”

Again, I considered asking about Bryce. Again, I didn’t. “Why? Why did you do it in those places?”

“You mean, was it just out of convenience? Or because the danger turned me on?” She delivered the last question in a hushed tone, then answered them both with a single answer. “Yes.”

I groaned. “Want to see what the bathrooms here are like?”

Avery laughed out loud. “I’ve seen them. Not sexy.” I deflated a little before she added, “But I know a way up onto the roof...”

I waved the server down. “We’re ready for the check.”

*

“Yes,” Avery sighed. “Oh, yes.”

She clutched the back of my neck, pulling me down to her as we fucked. Our kiss was hot and wet, as wild as the situation that we were in.

I could hear the bustle of the market below us—people asking about the price of strawberries or lettuce, the musicians playing bluegrass. Their murmur, their laughter, their presence pressed right up against the edges of my comfort zone. Hysteria threatened from the wings. Would someone hear us?

Would someone come through the rooftop door that we couldn't lock?

"You feel it, don't you?" Avery whispered. "The danger. Isn't it exciting?"

I saw the same hysteria that I felt reflected back at me in her face, only she transformed it. She buzzed off of it as much as she had those two Bloody Marys.

And I realized then and there that it *was* exciting, if only to see what it did to my otherwise cute, smiling wife.

"So you like a little danger?" I asked.

"Yes." She sighed, and I didn't know if she was replying or moaning. She pulled me over her until her quick panting filled my ears. Barely, just barely, I heard her question. "Can't you tell?"

She came beneath me, a quiet storm of an orgasm packed behind her clenched teeth and flaring nostrils. I fucked her faster, wanting to join her. *So you like danger?* I thought. *The danger of getting caught? Of being discovered?*

Another thought followed closely. A vision of the future. Avery in a bar—the Avery of today with her long hair held back in a ponytail, still wearing her teal blue scrubs as if she'd just stepped out of the ER. A man touches her arm. She turns, her face lighting up as she sees him. Sees Bryce. She looks around, risk in the crowd. Risk of being caught. Risk of being recognized. And when he steps into her, draws her close, draws her lips to his—

"Uh, fuck," I groaned. The vision fled, a smoke ring in the wind, and I was back in my body.

Back on the rooftop. Back with my cock in my wife's still panting body.

"Shh, shh," Avery whispered, drawing me against her as I came. Her lips sought mine, just as I'd imagined Bryce's a moment before. Our kiss started heated, but broke when Avery couldn't stop smiling.

"What?" I asked.

Avery giggled. "With all the talk of fresh produce down there, I'm getting hungry again."

I laughed with her. The twisted vision of her and Bryce lingered, but only barely. "Come on, let's get some arugula and berries."

"Man of my own heart."

We liked to party, and coke always made her horny. Bryce's words tore through me like bullets.

Had times changed so much? "You know me, I'm an open book," I said.

4.

"Have you ever had a one-night stand?" I asked Sunday night.

"Yeah. A couple of times."

"Really? I thought you didn't approve of casual sex."

Avery's smile was almost feral, cutting a look up at me through her lashes. "Well, just because I don't approve of it now doesn't mean I didn't make those mistakes."

"So they were mistakes?"

She draped her arms around me. "Everything that wasn't with you was a mistake."

"That's sweet, but I don't believe you."

“Okay, maybe I’m being a little sentimental. Let’s just say, though, that when I got to college, I...tried a lot of things.”

My cock hardened. “Like what?”

She kissed me on the lips softly and released me from the embrace, stepping away. “Oh, this and that.”

I wanted to know more. I almost blurted out one of the things Bryce has said—a foursome, free blowjobs for your boyfriend’s friends, lesbian sex—but I couldn’t. Again, I wanted to know but didn’t.

Avery laughed. “You look all conflicted. That’s pretty sexy.”

“You’re enjoying this, aren’t you?” I said.

“Yeah, a little. But so are you.” Her dimples emerged, somehow making it harder to connect her with the woman she was hinting at. “I’m sorry. I’m just not used to talking about it. It feels like another life.”

But can you truly outgrow something like that? I wondered. It was that insecurity that rode beneath the surface of everything. Would I feel this tense forever?

Being the supporting, understanding husband that I wanted to be, I said, “We don’t have to if you don’t want to.”

“Oh, you know that’s not true. You want to hear some stories, and you know that I’ve got some stories to tell.”

My face started to warm. She had me there. “Part of me does, yeah. It’s just sexy, hearing this new side of you. New to me, anyway.”

“That’s because you don’t know any of the details. It’s all hypothetical right now.”

“It is, which is why the other part of me doesn’t want to know.”

“You’re a complicated man, Chris.” She didn’t sound condescending or upset. It was merely a statement of fact. “When you’re ready then. Just ask.”

Just ask. The onus was on me. Thing was, I’d already worked up the nerve to ask her and had received a non-answer. I couldn’t decide if I’d dodged a bullet or not, and wasn’t ready to try again.

Not Sunday.

Only problem was that on Friday, someone was meeting Bryce. Someone married, someone who matched Avery’s description, and someone who’d done all kinds of crazy things with him. And despite all the evidence that it was Avery, I stubbornly believed that maybe it wasn’t.

If Avery was planning on meeting up with Bryce, then she’d already been in contact with him for at least a few weeks. He’d told me how he’d reached out to her, and so they’d at least discussed drinks.

I thought back to the last couple of weeks, to whether she’d been acting strangely. It was hard to tell

since I’d been traveling for a week of it, and things had already been out of the ordinary because of my new responsibilities.

Avery hadn’t started taking on strange shifts, though. She hadn’t been any different in the bedroom—either crazier or less so. She didn’t close windows on her computer when I came into the room, or hide her text messages from me.

But what if this wasn’t her first time? If she had gotten used to fucking a bunch of men when she’d been with Bryce, maybe she hadn’t ever outgrown it?

Ah, fuck. I was talking myself in circles. I just needed to talk to her about it—ask her about it.

Monday, I came home determined to do just that. I had all kinds of conversation starters. *Avery, what's the craziest thing you did in college?* Or, *Avery, remember that guy from the photo? Bryce, I think his name was? Any stories about him?* Or more straightforward, *Have you ever had sex with more than one guy at once?*

But before I could get to any of that, she dropped a bomb. “Hey, I forgot to mention it, but I’m going out with Nicki Friday night.”

My stomach churned. “Oh, yeah?”

Avery seemed tense. Or maybe that was me projecting. I swear, though, her voice sounded too modulated. “Yeah, we’ve been meaning to catch up. It’s been too long.”

Nicki and Avery had once been thick as thieves. They’d known each other since college. They’d been each other’s maids of honor. You look up BFF and you’ll see a picture of the two of them. Since Nicki had her baby, though, we’d seen less of her. The whole situation was totally plausible, which is why I just smiled and said, “Sounds great. It’s been a long time since you’ve had a girls’ night out.”

Avery laughed. “Not really a girls’ night. Just two girls.”

“Well, you know what I mean.”

What I really meant was that this was really convenient. Nicki was Avery’s “wild” friend. She was a fun girl, but I’d always figured that she’d be the one that a guy like Bryce would be drawn to, not Avery. In fact, aside from the fact that her name didn’t start with A and her hair was light brown, should could have been Avie.

She’d also gone to Brown with the two of them, must have known about them, so was the perfect person to cover for my wife.

I hated that thought. Covering for her. Was that a thing that honest people did? Help their best friends cheat on their spouses? If I could stop and think

rationality, I'd probably realize that it didn't sound like Nicki. I just couldn't stop and think rationally. Things were moving too fast.

Later that night, when we were getting ready for bed, I gently probed for more. "So where are you two going?"

"I'm not sure yet. Nicki's really the one who set it all up. Knowing Nic, we'll go out somewhere in the city. Maybe dinner, then a bar."

"And get hit on all night," I blurted. To cover, I quickly added, "Isn't that how it used to work back in the day?"

"I don't know about *all* night." Avery paused where she was standing by the dresser. She looked over her shoulder at me, then pulled off her t-shirt. "I mean, we eventually settled on some guys."

The jeans went next, and I was mesmerized by her wiggling hips. She had an ass made to wear thongs, and this small, black one with the white fringe was one of my favorites.

I barely saw it. Or rather, I saw it and thought of Bryce seeing it Friday night. Of seeing her reach back between her shoulder blades and deftly unsnap her bra.

"What?" Avery asked.

"What?" I echoed dumbly.

Avery laughed. "You're looking at me with that look again. The intense one."

"Sorry, just thinking about...." I didn't want to say what. I was ashamed.

"Of what happened after we settled on some guys?" Avery turned, her ripe breasts drawing my eyes. "Thinking about what would happen if I really liked a guy I met?"

I licked my lips. That wasn't what I was thinking...until that moment.

"What would happen?"

Avery crossed the room in nothing but her thong. Her nipples rode her tits hard and high. “If I liked him, I’d let him buy me a drink. We’d dance a little. And maybe I’d give him my number.”

Her answer felt true to her. It’s how we met, in fact, although we’d also spent hours just talking, getting to know one another. Still, I felt a little disappointed by the tame answer.

Avery settled into my lap and put her arms around me. She always smelled good, even at the end of the day. She rarely wore perfume, and didn’t need it. I loved her natural, earthy sweet scent.

Smiling down at me, she continued. “Now, if I thought the guy was hot, maybe I’d skip all that and just take him back to my place.”

It was like she’d wrapped her lips around my cock without even touching me. I was up. I was hard. And I was totally blown away. She kissed me in my stunned silence before pulling back and regarding me all self-satisfied.

“And yes, I did do that a couple of times.” She sank to the floor between my legs and pulled my boxers down. “And yes, I fucked them. But not before teasing them a little.”

With that, Avery dipped her head and swallowed me into her warm, wet mouth. I moaned, falling back onto my elbows as her mouth danced along my dick.

I’d been thinking a lot about her blowjobs recently—about how she does this thing with her tongue along my crown, how she knows exactly how hard to suck, how fast to bob along me. She’d learned all those things somewhere. She’d practiced them until she’d perfected that technique.

I looked down at her. She looked up at me. Her green eyes sparkled, like she was reading my thoughts. Like she knew how crazy it made me thinking of her doing this with other guys.

Doing? Or did? Or will do?

I shut my eyes and fought off the ambush of my orgasm. Not so fast. Not so quickly. But I saw her in a bar, sitting alone until a man joined her. Faceless but attractive, he'd buy her a drink. She'd let him. Laugh with him. Take him back to her place and go down on him.

And then that man became Bryce. And the bar was one I knew. One we went to all the time. And there I was, standing in the crowd, watching them flirt. Watching them catch up on old times.

When I looked down at her again, her eyes were closed, too. Was she imagining Bryce right now? Imagining what she'd like to do with him when they met up?

I couldn't fight it off any longer. Didn't want to. I thought of Avery's lips wrapped around Bryce and exploded with a fury.

Avery took it like she always took it, swallowing with expert skill that now had me wondering.

Not a drop escaped—not a drop ever escaped, unless she did it intentionally.

I flopped back onto the bed, drained. Avery crawled up beside me, pulling my boxers back into place. "You're so good at that," I said to the ceiling.

Avery's laugh was throaty, which was even sexier. As if echoing my own thoughts, she said,

"I've had some practice." She laughed again when she felt my cock twitch in her hand. "So that really turns you on."

It wasn't a question, but I considered it like it was one. Did it turn me on thinking about her past?

Yes. Did it turn me on thinking about her meeting up with Bryce behind my back? As fucked up as it was, it did. It was a big, nasty paradox.

Avery crawled up beside me as we settled under the covers. I said, "I don't really get it myself, but yeah."

“Not so confusing,” Avery said. She kissed my neck, crawling over me into a straddle. “I was

thinking about it. It’s kind of like the whole sexist notion of wanting an angel in the kitchen, a devil in the bedroom. Only, the past is safer. You can hear about my one night stands and not be threatened.”

“That’s true.” Only, it wasn’t just the past that was turning me on.

“But it’s not as simple as that,” Avery said.

My face lit up. Did she suspect my real fantasy? And was that what it was? A fantasy? “What’s not simple?” I asked.

“The angel and devil thing,” she said. “Nothing’s so black and white. Back in school, it wasn’t like I was some kind of nymphomaniac. I was like any other girl.... Well, maybe a little more adventurous, but I studied hard just like everyone else. I definitely was in the library more than in bars or other guys’ bedrooms. I had a bunch of friends, and no, we didn’t all fool around. I was normal.”

I nodded. It made sense, and softened part of the past. But if she wasn’t a total devil in the past, then she wasn’t a total angel in the present. She had her faults. She had her temptations....

Avery pulled back and looked down at me, a smile spreading across her face. “What are you thinking about? You just got all hard.”

“Umm....” Shit. “Thinking about Friday.”

“Oh?”

“And Nicki.”

Avery giggled. “Of course. You’ve always had a thing for her.”

“No, not like that.” Well, maybe I did. Nicki was a hot brunette with an outgoing personality who liked to flirt. Everyone had a thing for her.

“So *what about* me and Nicki and Friday night?”

“Well...” I scrambled. “Did you two ever pick up just one guy?”

I was grasping, but as soon as I saw my wife’s face turn red, I realized I’d inadvertently taken hold of something.

“Are you asking if I’ve ever had a threesome with another woman?” Avery adjusted herself over me, placing my cock against her slick entrance. “What is it with guys and that fantasy?”

I groaned as she sank over me. She was sodden.

“Is that a yes?” I asked. My chest felt so tight that I could barely breathe.

Avery undulated her body over mine, leaning over to drape her tits against my chest. Her voice was a whisper, tickling my ear. “No, we never picked up a guy together.”

Of course not.

“But I have had a threesome.”

I gasped.

I could barely formulate my question. “Another girl, or two guys?”

“Yes.”

Oh shit.

If I hadn’t just come, I would have. I almost did anyway.

“Does it shock you? Does it get you all *hard*?” She squeezed down on my shaft with her pussy.

“You didn’t...really....” I said. She felt so good, and her her words were so bad.

She pulled back to look me in the eye. “Yes. Really. I told you, when I got to college, I tried a lot of things.”

“Did you like it?”

She did. I could see it in the brightness of her face. “It was fun. I’m glad I tried it.”

“Want to try it again some time?” I meant with me, but as the words left my mouth, I thought of the darker interpretation of the question.

Avery laughed. “Are you asking to have a threesome?”

I blushed, suddenly embarrassed. “Never mind.”

“I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to shut you down.” She looked at me semi-seriously. “With another girl, or a guy?”

Another girl was the easy answer. The safer one. But the more honest one was another guy. And if I was being totally honest, I didn’t even need to be a part of it. So I went with her own vague answer.

“Yes.”

Avery laughed. “And the hidden agenda emerges. I knew you were hiding something.”

“No, that’s not it.”

“Oh? You don’t want to watch me go down on another woman as you fuck me?” I groaned before I could help it, and my balls tightened. “See? You like that thought. It turns you on.”

It did, but only as a fantasy. “I just want you, baby. I swear.”

She eyed me shrewdly. “So if I came home with Nicki on Friday, you’d kick her out?”

“She’s married....”

“What if we made some kind of deal with her husband?”

I had no clue whether she was teasing me or not, but her logic was easy to follow: a threesome with Nicki and my wife in exchange for a threesome with Nicki, Nicki’s husband, and Avery. I loved that second part almost as much as the first.

“Not worth it,” I said.

“You’re a bad liar, but I’ll pretend to buy it.”

“Avery....”

“Maybe Friday, Nicki and I will do a test run. She’s bi, you know.”

I groaned. Clutching her hips, I started thrusting up into her to meet each down thrust.

“What do you think, baby? You like the idea of me and Nicki making out? Of falling into bed together? Of me pulling off her skin tight jeans to reveal her wet pussy?”

Of Bryce behind Avery, naked, cock in hand as he pushed her face between Nicki’s legs. As he pressed into Avery, filling her, making her moan as she ate out her best friend—

“Oh, fuck!” I rammed up into Avery, pulling her down and deep into me, and erupted. Avery was right behind me, joining me with a wail.

Our lips sought one another to console and comfort as the fantasy talk faded. I clung to her, willing away the scene I’d imagined. Willing away Friday night’s fucked up possibility.

As our bodies cooled, the sheets twisted around us without covering, Avery said, “I’m just teasing, you know.”

I got my breathing under control before answering. “You didn’t have threesomes in college?”

“No, I mean about Friday. And Nicki.”

“Yeah, I know.” About that specific version of Friday, anyway.

“I love you, Chris. And if you ever want to try...anything, let’s talk about it. Okay?”

“I’m not going to ask you for a threesome,” I said, because it was the right thing for a husband to say.

“But if you ever wanted to....”

She sounded worried. “It’s just a fantasy. I don’t really.”

“Okay.”

“Good night, love.”

“Good night.”

5.

Avery was going to meet up with Bryce Friday night. There were too many facts to come to any other conclusion. She definitely dated him back in college. Every confession about her college experience confirmed the crazy things Bryce said she’d done. And she was going out to a bar the same night that he’d said he was meeting her.

I should have said something to her. Anything. I should have stopped this huge mistake before it could be made. But if she’d already made plans with him, hadn’t the mistake already happened? If she didn’t go through with it Friday, wouldn’t it be just a matter of time?

Yes, it would! I could never trust her after that, confrontation or no. I’d always wonder if she actually was working her late shift, or if she’d traded with someone else. I’d always wonder if she’d snuck out to meet up with her ex, who was now living in town.

It was toxic. In a way, asking the question was worse than not. I could feel it pulling us apart, even before it happened. I couldn't confront her. I wouldn't. If she did what she felt like she had to do, I'd deal with it then. Until that moment, though, I was going to let it go.

And in that freedom, I found something else—excitement. Excitement so sharp it cut to the bone.

Excitement so profound I wondered if I'd go mad from it. I felt high. I felt crushed, and even higher for it. I watched Avery go through her week, as sweet and comfortable as ever, and saw this vixen.

This sexual being that no man could contain.

Thing was, I didn't want Avery to know that I knew about Bryce. I didn't want her to change her plans, for one, but my reasoning for secrecy went deeper than that. Darker than that. It turned me on.

Some fucked up part of me wanted her to do it. Wanted her to cheat.

Did that mean I could forgive her? What if it was only the one time? How could I ever know that it was?

"Everything okay?" Avery asked Wednesday night.

"Yeah, why?"

"Nothing. I just miss you is all. I should have switched my shifts."

She'd worked a late night shift last night. I hadn't been able to sleep, tossing and turning as I wondered if she really was working. I almost called the hospital to check, but was proud that I hadn't.

Wednesday, I'd worked late to catch up on all the things I should have been doing Monday and Tuesday but couldn't as I grappled with the Bryce situation. Or so I told myself. I was still grappling, and working late was easier than facing Avery. In fact, I even stopped by the local watering hole for a drink, just so I could use the excuse that I was out at an impromptu happy hour with coworkers.

“I’ve been exhausted, too,” I said, helping her out. “Trying to get caught up after being out last week.”

That was the truth—especially the *trying* part. That wasn’t going so well.

“Yeah, that’s probably it,” she said.

*

I was more careful after that. Avery was sharp, and she knew how to read me. I worked late again Thursday night—the final night before the big, fateful day.

When I got home, she was out on the back patio, enjoying the warm summer evening with a glass of wine. “Hey, honey,” I said, kissing her just as I always did.

She looked tired, but happy to see me. “You’re home. Yay. Go change and join me out here.”

When I got back downstairs, Avery was still out on the patio, checking something on her phone

—confirming her plans with Bryce?

She laughed at whatever she read, her golden bangs obscuring her face before she pushed them back. God, I loved that smile. It brought out her cheeks like the sun breaking through the clouds.

Standing there in the wide-open floor plan of our town home, bathed in shadow, I realized just how much I was willing to sacrifice not to lose her light.

Avery thumbed through her phone, browsing, I realized, not texting or writing an email. She reached for her glass, finishing off the last swallow of white. I grabbed another glass and the half-full bottle of Chardonnay, and went out to join her.

“Refill?” I asked.

Avery darkened her phone and set it face down on the table. A small part of me squirmed at that.

“Please.”

I gave her a healthy pour. “So how was work?”

“You read about the big accident this morning?” she asked.

“Closed all lanes of 95. Something about an overturned tractor trailer?”

“Yeah. Four other cars were also involved. We were the closest hospital.”

Avery rarely spoke of the ER horrors. She compartmentalized well, although sometimes if something was really troubling her, she’d share. I sat down, knowing that I was here to listen, not console.

“It was ugly, Chris. One of the cars was a van. A family. Two boys.”

I inhaled sharply, holding my breath, waiting for the inevitable blow.

“We had to perform emergency surgery on the youngest one. The children’s hospital was too far away, and he was in critical condition.”

She took a sip of her wine, held it in her mouth to savor it, then swallowed.

“We saved him. We saved all of them. No deaths.” She broke out into a smile. “Today was a good day.”

I released that breath, and all the tension that was bottled up behind it. I reached out and touched her hand. She moved easily into my lap.

“You never know what life will throw at you,” I said.

Avery smiled, breaking the introspective seriousness of the moment.

“Yolo,” she said with a laugh.

“What?”

“Oh, come on, old man. *You only live once?* It’s days like this that make me realize that we only have one life to live, and that even though we don’t realize it, we’re fighting for each and every one.”

I tried to parse what she was saying with the Friday situation. Was she deciding not to meet Bryce? Or was she using her *carpe diem* outlook on life to have the affair? The second possibility resonated more between my legs, but didn’t make sense based on the sequence of events.

“I’m glad that you’re going out tomorrow,” I found myself saying.

“I should stay. We haven’t had many nights together since you’ve been back.”

I laughed, and it almost sounded natural. “I just told you I was glad you were going out. Yolo, right? I’ll be here when you get back.”

She nodded, picking up her wine. Our view from the back patio wasn’t much—the backs of other town homes where people hung their laundry out to dry. In the dark, though, it felt magical. At last, she said, “I will be, too, you know. Whenever you go away, I’ll be here.”

She would be. I knew that. She wasn’t going to leave me. She wasn’t looking to have some prolonged affair with another man. I remembered that point in my conversation with Bryce so distinctly:

“Cheating?” Saying it tasted like sawdust in my mouth.

“A fling. Nothing is quite as exciting.”

A fling, then. I could handle a fling. I’d be there for her when it was over.

“So has Nicki picked a bar yet?”

“Mackenzie’s.”

“Dinner?”

She nodded. “So I probably won’t see you until after you come back.”

“Yeah.”

“Then let’s stop wasting time and go upstairs. Yola, right?”

Avery smiled. “Yo- *lo*, old man. Come on.”

6.

We made love that night, our bodies coming together, smooth, then sweaty. If tomorrow was the turning point in our marriage, I wanted her to go into it remembering this night. Remembering what she had at home.

I didn’t sleep much that night, and when I woke up, Avery was just emerging from the steamed up bathroom, a wet towel wrapped around her.

“Morning, babe. You look tired,” she said.

“I must have slept wrong.”

“TGIF then.” She winked, then dropped the towel.

I gasped. Her body was practically pink from the shower, fresh and clean. Her breasts hung round and ripe, and her nipples weren’t quite hard, but they weren’t soft, either. She crossed the room, comfortable in her nudity around me—and yet I saw her as if for the first time. She’d shaved her pussy, getting it as smooth as possible for her big reunion, and her skin glistened with lotion.

I watched her dress. Watched her remove a black thong and bra set that I may have recognized, but wasn’t quite sure. How could I ever take Avery’s lingerie for granted?

I groaned and dragged myself from bed, giving my wife’s backside one last, lingering look before getting clean.

In the shower, the mere thought of tonight had me hard. Like, really hard. I tried to fight it down.

I thought of work matters. I thought of reports I needed to write. But my mind kept going to Mackenzie's. To that first moment when Avery looked up and met Bryce's eyes. And with that thought came the erection, every time.

I heard the door to the bathroom open. Cooler air billowed against the shower curtain.

For a moment, I thought that she might be joining me. It had been forever since we'd shared a shower. Then I panicked. I had a huge erection. How could I explain that?

"Hello?"

"Don't mind me. Just in here to do my makeup."

"Makeup, huh? So you and Nicki planning on reliving old times?" It was the absolute wrong thing to say—especially after I'd been so careful all week long—but I was nervous. I was so focused on getting my cock to behave that it just popped out of my mouth.

Avery laughed, just beyond the pale curtain. Good, I hadn't spooked her. "Maybe we're planning on coming up with new ones."

All that effort to get my cock down was for naught. An image of the two women in one another's arms had me hard all over again. At least this time, the fantasy was more acceptable.

"The silence is telling. What's going on in there."

I heard the shower rings scrape along the rod a moment too late. "No, don't ____"

"Well, well, what do we have here?" Avery asked. There I was, standing with my cock in my hand and no means to cover myself. "Someone having some dirty thoughts?"

I sighed. I might as well come partially clean. "Been having a lot since I got back."

“Yes, you have,” she said. “Me and Nicki?”

Among others. “Yeah.”

She had already applied lip gloss, drawing me to her succulent mouth. “That could be fun. She’s a good kisser, you know.”

My eyes must have bugged out.

Avery laughed. “You know how college girls can be, always trying to get attention.”

“I...no, not really.”

Avery’s smile broadened. “So you’re sure you don’t want me to bring her home tonight? She’s already told me she thinks you’re pretty cute.”

“Just pretty cute? Forget it.”

“Ha. Fine, suit yourself.” She shut the curtain, leaving me alone once again. Alone, but never alone.

I finished up my shower before she finished her makeup. Luckily by then, my cock had tamed enough that I could walk out with some dignity. Avery was busy putting on mascara. I couldn’t remember the last time she’d put on mascara—especially for work. Maybe I was completely wrong.

Maybe she was meeting Bryce earlier, and her ruse with Nicki was just a means to stay with him longer.

I checked her dress. At first glance, it was a dress like all her others—sleeveless, knee-length, clingy yet not tight. Looking closer, though, I realized that the material was thin enough that in the right light and at a certain angle, I could make out the outline of her thong and the straps of her bra.

At work, she’d change out of the dress and into her scrubs, so this was a dress for later. For Bryce.

I slinked away before Avery turned and saw me hard again.

After that, the morning proceeded as normal. We ate breakfast. We checked the news on our devices. And then it was time to go to work.

“I’ll text you tonight when I know I’m coming home,” Avery said as we stood leaning against our respective cars.

“Sounds good. Have fun.”

“Oh, I will.”

And that was that.

*

The morning crept along, agonizingly slowly. I probably wrote some reports. I even sat in on a meeting about something, and made some important decisions about the future of our company, but I couldn’t remember what they were five minutes later. My mind was on Avery, wherever she was, whatever she was doing.

Actually, that’s not 100% true. My mind was on her getting fucked by Bryce—on her ex having her bent over the bathroom sink at Mackenzie’s, their eyes locked onto one another in the mirror, as he plowed her from behind.

I wanted to vomit. I wanted to jerk off. I could do neither. I was at work.

I was playing chicken with myself, and with my marriage. Ahead was Avery and her affair. Her fling. Whatever. I could still stop it. I could still intervene. And yet I didn’t. We got closer and closer to collision, and I still didn’t.

But my actions—or inactions, I suppose—weren’t the most troubling part. No, that was reserved for the reasons for my actions. Deep down inside me, I wanted Avery to have this fling. I wanted her to be happy, to reconnect with the sexual creature she’d been in her youth. I wanted her to go crazy one last time, and be there for her once she came home.

You only live once. We all had choices to make, good and bad decisions that we had to live with.

Every one of us had regrets. Would I regret not intervening? If I intervened, would I forever regret what could have been?

By the end of the day, I was determined not to do a thing, or say a word. I'd go home, grab a

burrito and a six pack, and watch a movie as Avery met Bryce in a bar wearing a dress thin enough to reveal the lines of her underwear beneath. Would she have her hair up? In a ponytail. Loose and around her shoulders? Yes, probably that.

I worked until six, if you could call it work. I don't know what I'd call it because I didn't remember what I did. I said goodbye to the few people left in the office on a Friday evening, went down to my car, and fully intended on driving home. Or at least to a fast food Mexican joint and the liquor store.

Instead, before I knew what I was doing, I was pulling up to Mackenzie's.

7.

I didn't know what my intentions were. I really didn't. Was I there to confront them? To catch them in the act? Or did I want to watch? To hide in the shadows as Avery blushed and flirted with another man?

The last thought stirred something deep inside of me—exciting yet uncomfortable.

“Will you be dining with us, or just going to the bar?” a woman asked from the host station at the door.

I looked past her, into the dim lighting of the restaurant. Friday happy hour was already in full swing, and the bar area was packed. Avery had mentioned something about dinner, so I figured they'd be dining.

Dining, I almost said before I played out that scene. What if I was wrong? What if Avery really was meeting up with Nicki, that they were having a heart-to-heart over dinner? She'd look up, see me, and what would I say then?

"Bar. I'm, uh, meeting someone." Not sure why I said that, but the hostess just waved me in.

Mackenzie's was a huge bar that existed in that middle ground between suburbs and the city. The bar took up most of the front of the main landing of the restaurant, loud and smelling of beer. I picked my way carefully through the throng, searching for Avery or Bryce—or Nicki, just in case. My heart palpitated against my ribs. I had to force myself to breathe. Twice, I thought I saw them, a blonde talking to a man a little rough around the edges. Both times, I was wrong.

The restaurant proper was actually half a landing down from the bar, spread out across the back.

High windows looked out over the Delaware River, where the last ships came out of the dying light. I watched a tugboat chug along, hauling nothing, because I was too afraid to search the tables below.

When I took a deep breath, my body trembled. My face was hot. Okay, you can do this. You can handle this, no matter what.

I tore my eyes from the window and looked across the tables. Part of me still thought this was all some coincidence. That I'd see Avery laughing with Nicki, beers set in front of them, plates half empty. That part ignored all the evidence of the last week. All the theories and suppositions that had been churning through me, grinding me down to nothing.

The restaurant was crowded, although it wasn't anything like the bar behind me. I looked along the windows first, finding no one. I checked the tables, assembled in neat rows like the squares of a chess board. No Avery. No Bryce.

For the span of half a minute, I wondered if they were here at all. Was there another Mackenzie's that I didn't know about? Or had they skipped the formalities of the restaurant all together? Ice flowed through my veins. I almost doubled over at the thought.

Then I saw them. Avery, head back, hair loose, laughing. She looked beautiful, even from across the room. She ran her fingers through her blond hair, tossing the rich waves. She was sitting in a horseshoe booth on the far wall, nearly out of sight from where I stood. It was about as private as things got, which is why I almost didn't see her. Or her companion.

My stomach fell. My heart clenched. My cock sang to life. She was with him.

She was with Bryce.

*

I faded back into the bar before she spotted me, although I'm not sure how much I cared any

longer. I ordered a lager and drained nearly half of it before setting it back down on the bar.

So this was real. Avery was out there with Bryce, having dinner with another man. She hadn't told me about him, and there could only be one reason for that—she intended to do something with him that she didn't want me to know about.

I was back to the question of whether I could handle this. Could I forgive her? Could I ever trust her again? How much did I love her?

"You good, man?" the bartender asked.

"Yeah."

"Kay. Want another?"

My beer was already empty. When had that happened?

“Just a water. Thanks.”

The bartender gave me a disapproving look, but filled a glass of water for me.

I loved Avery more than anything. I didn't want to lose her. I couldn't handle a life without her.

Clearly we had some issues in our marriage, but it wasn't too late. Not yet. I pushed back out of my chair, intending to go down there. To sit at her table. To say, *Hello*. I thought of their reactions. The guilt on her face. The confusion on Bryce's.

Or would he smile and clap me on the back. *So you're Avery's husband? No shit. Guess you liked the stories you heard about her....*

I hadn't told Avery about him. I'd had a secret, too. I'd known about this evening, yet let her go into it anyway like it was some kind of trap. Would she hate me for that? And what kind of fucked up logic was that, anyway? I was the one who should be hating....

I didn't. I couldn't. Never. Avery was Avery. Once upon a time, she'd done things that shocked me. That turned me on. That woman was still inside her, and as fucked up as it was, I wanted it to emerge again. I craved it.

But I couldn't let her do this. I just couldn't.

Rising, I pushed my way through the crowd. Back to the edge of the restaurant. Bryce was sitting closer to her now, his hand beneath the table. On her leg? Something more? He was whispering something to her, and she was blushing. Even from all the way across the room, I could see her beet red face.

I grasped the banister of the bar's landing as I swooned. As I watched Avery turn to him, look at him sharply as he kept sweet-talking her. It was like watching a hypnotist at work. I wanted to shout out. To break the spell.

I didn't need to. Someone else did.

A woman materialized before their table dressed in a pair of tight black jeans, heels, and layered tank tops that left her arms and shoulders bare. I recognized the little tattoo on her left shoulder blade

—a black *pi* symbol—before I recognized the woman. Nicki.

Confusion roiled through me. Nicki was really here? So that wasn't a ruse, after all?

I watched her slide into the horseshoe booth on the opposite side of Avery so that Bryce was between them. She said something, Bryce grinned, and then the two kissed. Like, really kissed, open, wet, passionate. Avery shifted beside them, looking shy but not uncomfortable.

What was it Avery had said the other night? *Maybe we'll have new adventures*. Something like that. I shivered, once again frozen in place. Frozen with indecision.

Bryce and Nicki separated, and Nicki smiled across him at my wife. She said something to Avery. A question. I felt the weight of it as I watched Avery consider. She looked at Bryce, who seemed to focus all his charm on her.

Avery picked up her wine glass and emptied it in one draw. Setting it down, she nodded. *Yes*. I didn't know what the question was, but she'd fucking said yes. My whole world fell apart in that head

nod. I hadn't known what I truly wanted until that moment—I was blinded by the illicit excitement of her possible infidelity, by the thought of her being so sexual, even for another man.

Now that it was here, it was too much. I should have said something. Should have stopped it.

Now, no matter what I did, it was too late. If I confront them, I'd stop the actual act, but not the intent.

And then I looked down to see Avery on her feet. Nicki rose with her, hugging her tightly. She leaned back. *You sure?* she seemed to say. Avery nodded, looking like someone sure of herself, yet sad to disappoint.

Bryce watched, lounging in the booth, one hand wrapped around the base of his pint glass. I knew disappointment when I saw it, and Bryce was the embodiment of it.

Avery waved at Bryce, then one last time at Nicki, and she was walking away. Was she going to the bathroom? Getting something from her car?

I just stood there, confused by what I'd just seen, watching Avery navigate through the checkerboard of tables. She had this self-satisfied smile on her face. She pulled out her phone and thumbed something in. A moment later, my phone buzzed.

[Avery]: Headed home. See you soon.

I read the message like it was in a foreign language. She was headed home? Like, the evening was over?

The evening was *over!* Avery wasn't headed to the bathroom, but was going home. Where I wasn't. And thanks to my unsettled tab, where I probably couldn't be before she was.

[Chris]: I'm not home. Let's meet somewhere for a drink.

It wasn't a lie.

Avery paused below as she read the message. I watched her consider it, smile, and type her response.

[Avery]: Sure. How about Dirty Martini?

Dirty Martini was just a couple blocks away from here, but far enough away that we wouldn't stumble upon Bryce by accident.

[Chris]: Meet you there in about fifteen minutes.

I made sure I was on the opposite side of the bar from Avery as she threaded her way through the crowd. Watching her go, I swear she had more pep in her step. Guys looked, checking her out in that thin dress of hers. A couple guys even looked like they might approach her, but didn't.

I waited until I was sure that she was gone before making my way back to the bar and settling my tab.

Fifteen minutes later, I'd moved my car closer to Dirty Martini and was ready to find out what the hell was going on.

8.

Dirty Martini was swankier than Mackenzie's, with polished table tops and specialty cocktail drinks. I could hear the rooftop bar bustling as I stepped up to the front doors. Inside was much more sedate.

Avery sat at the bar, a drink already in front of her, and two guys eyeing her up. My heart quivered at that. I approached before they could, although I briefly considered letting them move in first.

"Hey, stranger. Can you get me a drink?" I asked.

Avery turned to look at me through the curtain of her blond hair. "I think you're supposed to offer me the drink," she said.

"But you've already got one, and I don't. This seems more fair."

"Fine. Bartender, can you get this guy a..." She looked at me. "What are you drinking tonight?"

"I'll take a dirty martini."

Avery rolled her eyes. "How original."

I looked at her own olive-laden martini. "Uh huh."

The bartender raised his eyebrows at the two of us, a little annoyed. I mouthed, *A dirty martini*, with a nod, and he turned to make the drink that

the bar was named after.

“I have something to tell you. And you might be mad.”

I heard nervousness tremble in her voice. I was right there with her. “Okay.”

She released an unsteady breath. “I didn’t just meet up with Nicki tonight.”

“You didn’t?”

“We met up with one of her ex-boyfriends, too.”

“One of hers?” I blurted, forgetting that I was supposed to be ignorant of the situation.

Avery was too nervous to pick up on the slip. “Well, one of mine, too. I mean, same guy. Bryce.

You remember that photo you found a few months ago? Punk Rock? It was him. We both dated him at one point—at different times, I mean.” She flipped her hair from her face. “I’m babbling. Are you mad?”

“No.” Fear felt like a tightly wound spring in my chest. Time to confess. She’d been honest. My turn. “I....” I blew out a quiet breath. “...knew.”

“You know? You know what?” Avery asked, confused.

“Not *know*. *Knew*. ”

“You’re not making sense.” She didn’t look upset, just...puzzled.

I sighed. “I knew you were meeting up with Bryce tonight. I knew since last week.”

She blinked, opened her mouth to speak, then closed it again when she couldn’t figure out what to say. Her eyes narrowed as she worked though it. My face grew hotter. She stayed quiet, so I spoke.

“I sat next to him on the plane. Coming back from Seattle. I didn’t know who he was at first, and he got to talking about some college girlfriend he was meeting up with here. He called her *Avie*, but he basically described you.”

Avery took a sip of her martini, watching me intensely. *Go on*, she said without speaking.

“He said that you were special. That he even asked to marry you, but you turned him down.”

Her eyes flickered at that, but still she said nothing.

“I didn’t really believe it was you. I mean, the stories he had....” I tried to gauge her reaction, but got nowhere. “I mean, I won’t lie, I thought it was pretty hot hearing about all those stories.”

She nodded slowly, more to herself than to me.

“But still, mostly I was convinced that he was talking about someone else.”

“So that’s why you suddenly became curious,” she said quietly.

“Yeah. And when you started confirming some of the stories....”

The corners of Avery’s lips went up. “You were convinced.”

“Yeah.”

“Why didn’t you just tell me about meeting him? It would have been easier to talk about...things.”

“Because he told me he was meeting up with you tonight. He told me he thought you were looking for a fling.”

She didn’t look mad, but she was too calm to really be calm. “So you wanted to test me.”

“No.” It was a gut response. It also probably wasn’t true. “Well, not exactly.”

“Explain.”

Okay, so maybe she *was* mad.

“I was conflicted.” I paused, and she eyed me sideways. “It turned me on. A part of me, anyway.”

“What...did?”

“The idea of you actually having a fling with him.”

Avery’s eyes went wide. “Now I know you’re messing with me. No more games, Chris.”

“I’m serious.” I felt embarrassed, but at the time, I felt like I’d finally stepped out from under the shadow that had been hanging over me all week. “The thought of you actually meeting up with another man—”

“Behind your back,” she inserted.

“Yes, behind my back—was just...sexy. And wrong. So, so wrong. But sexy.” I shrugged. “I seriously can’t explain it.”

“So if I had gone back to Bryce’s place tonight, let him fuck my brains out, then crawled back home and told you I was out with Nicki, you wouldn’t have been upset?”

“Of course I would have been upset.” Even as she said it, my blood pressure rose—from anger, from excitement. “But at the same time...I don’t know.”

Avery stirred her martini with a toothpick, still speared with an olive. She said, “You know, this whole time, I thought that it was *you* who was thinking of having an affair.”

I blinked at that. “What? No way.”

“Way. You were acting so strange. Asking all these weird questions. I thought that you’d met someone younger. More exciting.”

“I don’t know that that’s possible.”

“It is. It always is.” There was fire in her words, as softly spoken as they were.

“Fine, for the sake of argument, it’s always a possibility. I just don’t think it’s very likely.

Especially now.”

“Because you like the thought of me being some slut who can’t control herself. Who could sleep with other guys behind your back? What the fuck, Chris?”

Her anger flared up at last. I knew it was coming. That it *had* to come. Yet now that it was here, I was glad. This was something that we could deal with—open, honest communication. At fucking last.

“You know that’s not what I meant—”

“Then what did you mean?”

I took a slow breath to organize my thoughts. “I love you.” I winced a little as her face tightened, moving on quickly. “I love you for *you*. For the good and the bad. I fell in love with you when you went on that tirade about the last season of *Lost*.”

I caught the barest hint of a smile beneath her fury. I hurried on.

“From that point on, I was lost.” I grimaced at the unintended pun. Her smile peeked out even more. “I knew that I wanted to spend the rest of my life with you. For better or worse. I...fuck, Avery, I meant it.”

When she spoke, her voice was soft, her words more contemplative than angry. “Even if I slept with another man behind your back? You really would have been okay with that?”

I hesitated. I didn't know, even after a week of contemplation. "In the end... I don't know. At times, I thought I could be. I figured that I could forgive you anything, even an...." I almost said *affair*. "Even a fling." That sounded softer. "But in the end, I didn't want to risk it. So I came out."

Avery lifted her eyebrows. "To Mackenzie's?"

"Yeah. I went to stop you, I guess."

"And then you saw me leave."

I nodded. "I was surprised to see that Nicki was actually there."

At last, the smile came out. When she looked at me like that, like she had an exciting secret she was about to tell me, I realized how much I loved her. And how much I'd miss seeing her. "Nicki is actually Bryce's *Avie* you know. Not me."

I couldn't comprehend what she was saying at first. I played it over in my head, trying to understand the shape of it. *Nicki is actually Bryce's Avie?*

"But that doesn't make any sense."

Avery shook her head. "Her real name's Annika Violet. A.V. That's what she went by in college."

A.V. Initials, not a shortening of Avery. "Bryce said she was blonde."

Avery was on the brink of laughter. "She was. Back in school. People used to think we were sisters."

"So...."

"So those stories Bryce told you about? That wasn't me. That was Nicki."

I didn't know how to react. The crazy past that I'd constructed for my wife—the one it had taken nearly a week to even half-believe—came crumbling down around me. I felt relief and, confusingly, disappointed.

“I’m sorry,” Avery said, touching my hand.

“Why?”

“You look like I just told you the Easter Bunny wasn’t real,” she said.

I looked at her—didn’t realize I hadn’t been looking at her—and she smiled at me. I said, “I’m sorry. I’m just...it’s all just a lot to take in.”

“Ditto, Chris. Ditto.” She pulled her stool closer to me. “You really thought I’d sleep with another man behind your back?”

I shrugged. “I also thought that you were having regular threesomes with Bryce’s friends. That you couldn’t get enough of his cock, so he had to bring in reinforcements.” Okay, that was the martini talking.

Avery laughed, surprise written across her face. “Nicki did that? Oh wow, I knew she was a slut...” She looked at me, suddenly getting it. “And you thought that I was that slut.”

“I’m glad you weren’t.”

“But not really,” she said. Avery sighed. “You’re disappointed.”

I didn’t want to lie to her anymore, but I didn’t want to answer that, either. I’d get over it. It was a crazy thing to be upset about, anyway—that my wife hadn’t been a whore back in college?

“I know how we can fix this. At least partly,” she said.

“There’s nothing to fix.”

Avery ignored me, sliding off her stool. “Come on. The bathrooms here are private. And nice and large.”

I looked at her. Even with my brain made sluggish in my melodrama, I could follow what she was saying. “Oh yeah?” I said, a hint of a smile.

“Yeah, want to explore them with me?”

*

The bathroom at Dirty Martini was, indeed, nice and large. It was also a private room, with a lock and a heavy door that would shut out sound. Almost like they intended it to be used the way we were intending to use it.

Avery was all over me as soon as the door shut, our lips crashing into one another, our tongues fighting. She pushed me back against the pedestal sink before dropping to her knees and going for my cock.

“I may not have been like Nicki back in school, but I did do this a couple times,” she said. She freed me, finding me thick and hard. “Yummy.”

She wasn’t just putting on a show. I could see the hunger on her face, feel it in the way she wrapped her lips around my shaft and worked me with her tongue. I leaned back on the sink, my knees going weak.

Avery popped off of me. “What else did you think I did back then? Other than blow his friends?”

She bobbed along me as I spoke, listening, watching me. I felt exposed, so spoke the truth. “He said that one time, the two of you hooked up with another couple. The guys watched the girls get it on before joining.”

“And you thought that was hot,” she asked, her voice throaty.

“Yes.”

Avery stroked me with her hand as she rose, mashing her mouth to mine in a hard kiss. She placed my hands on her dress, encouraging me to draw it up. I enthusiastically took the hint.

“That was actually me,” Avery whispered against my ear before she brushed past me, bending over the sink.

“What?”

Avery looked at me in the reflection of the mirror. “We don’t have much time, and I need a cock inside me.”

I pushed her dress up over her hips, pulled her thong to the side, and pressed in behind her.

“You’re so wet.”

“You still don’t know the full story of tonight,” she said, full of suggestion.

My mind fumbled over what to ask. What avenue to explore. Avery made my decision for me.

“I wasn’t *Avie*.” She snickered. “I was the girlfriend of Bryce’s friend, Reggie.”

I tried to reconstruct the events as told by Bryce, but with my cock buried in my wife in the confines of the bar’s bathroom, thinking at all was too difficult.

“You said you never had sex with Nicki,” I said instead.

“No, I didn’t. I said we never picked up a guy together. We *definitely* have had sex.”

I don’t know how I didn’t come. I was on the brink. My balls were swollen, swinging hard against the soft lace of her thong with each hard thrust.

“And that night?” I asked.

“Was actually the first time we met. I’d never even kissed another girl then. By the end of the night, though, I’d done so much more.” She sighed as she reminisced. “That was a crazy, fucking night.”

“Sounds it.”

“I still remember how good it felt to have Nicki’s tongue on my clit, Reggie’s cock in my mouth, and Bryce fucking my pussy.” She groaned, dropping her head between her shoulders as she lifted her ass to me. She was close. I was closer. “I’ll confess, when Nicki asked me to join them tonight, I actually thought about it.”

So that's what tonight was all about? My body seized up. My heart seized up. I rammed one last,

hard time into her body, filling her with as much cock as I had to give, and exploded inside of her.

9.

We left the bathroom about ten minutes after we'd entered—nothing too crazy or noticeable. Still, it felt like the whole bar was looking at us knowingly as we made our way back to our seats, hand-in-hand.

I swear, even the bartender looked at us with a barely concealed smile. "Another round?"

"Please," Avery responded for us.

He mixed our martinis in front of us as we smiled and giggled together like high school sweethearts. When he left, I said, "He knows."

Avery confirmed it. "He does. You think that he thinks we just met?"

I hadn't thought of that. It sent a wave of heat through me.

"Exciting, isn't it?" she asked. She raised a glass. "To being exciting together."

I smiled and tipped my martini to hers.

When we were alone again, I said, "So Nicki wanted to relive old times with you?"

"Apparently she did." She rolled her eyes. "I didn't even know he was going to be there tonight, you know. I had a feeling that she was up to something, but I thought she just wanted to talk. When I walked in and saw Bryce...."

"So you didn't know?" I asked, surprised.

“I hadn’t even thought about him until you started bringing up college. But you knew he’d be there.” She shook her head. “Man, if you’d told me that he would be there, I never would have gone.”

“You could have.”

She looked at me, puzzling out the meaning. I flushed, seeking to change the subject. “So did you and Nicki get together? Since college, I mean?”

She didn’t immediately answer, clinging to my original statement about being able to meet up with Bryce, maybe? She studied me, her focus shifting from eye to eye. At last, she asked, “Since we got married, you mean?”

I shivered. Was that excitement I felt, or jealousy?

“Would you be upset if we had?”

I blew out a shaky breath. “There isn’t an easy answer to that.”

“And that’s an interesting answer.” She shook her head. “We haven’t. Since I *met* you, I’ve never done anything with anyone else. Not with Nicki. Not with other men. No one.”

I believed her. It was a little disappointing, but I totally believed her.

Then, with a twinkle in her eye, she added, “I didn’t know that I could until now.”

I gasped. Avery giggled. Said: “You really thought that I would?”

“I didn’t know what to think. I was confused.” I sipped my drink. It was going down fast. “You said you thought about it. Were you just teasing?”

Guilt spread across her cheeks. “Well, I mean, I did think about it. But not seriously.” Then she smiled slyly. “Although Nicki did offer to return the favor if I did. With you and me.”

I groaned. “So that’s what you meant when you teased me before. I thought you meant working something out with her husband.”

“Well, I did. Kind of, anyway. Like I said, I had no idea Bryce would be there tonight. But Nicki and her husband...well, they’re swingers.”

“No way,” I said.

“Yeah.” She let me chew on that. “I probably should have told you that, too.”

“Has he ever hit on you—”

“No! No, you know Paul. He’d never do something like that. Mostly, Nicki and I would get together and she’d fill me in on their adventures.” She laughed softly to herself. “Makes sense though, right, now that you know more about her history? Of course she’d settle down with someone as...open-minded?”

“And you? Was that who you were hoping to marry?”

Avery laughed. “Please. I’m not Nicki.”

“But you did get wild in college.”

“You really do like hearing about that, don’t you?”

I was proud that I didn’t look away. “I do.”

“I got a little wild. Not like Nicki, and honestly, the night we got together as a foursome was probably the wildest night of my life. But I did hook up with my roommate once....” She blushed. “I tried anal sex with Reggie, too. Just the one time.”

“And a threesome with two guys? That with Reggie?” I was beginning to wonder if Reggie was Avery’s version of Bryce.

“Nah. That was early in med school. Longer story.” When she saw my anguished look, she giggled. “I promise I’ll tell you. Just not tonight.”

“Okay.” I wrung my hands together. “So there’s no part of you that wants to...go back there? To that wilder life? You...you said that you thought about joining Nicki and Bryce—”

“Thought. That’s all.”

“But you thought about it.” I stared at her intensely. She stared back. Then she broke into a smile.

“You’ve got that look again. Only this time, you’re not thinking about what I did in the past.”

“No.”

“Here’s the truth. When I met you, I knew that you were special. I went into our relationship without agendas. Without any of my past. I wanted the life that we lived to be about us. Understand?”

I nodded.

She grinned. “But now that I know you’ve got a kinky streak, maybe we can try a few things.”

My jaw nearly hit the floor. “What are you saying?”

“I’ve had a lot of fun reliving the past this week. And you know why? Because I’ve been reliving those things with you. I’d like to keep doing that.”

“Nicki?”

Avery’s laugh came hearty and bold. “I could talk to her.” She reached out, lacing her fingers over mine on the bar. “But what I’d really like to do is come up with some new experiences to share with you.”

My chest tightened. “Bryce?”

“No, not Bryce. We dated for like a second, and from what I remember, he’s not even that good.

He's just cocky. You're a much better lover."

I warmed to hear that.

"But I suppose he had this mystique about him. The bad boy. Still has it."

"So you *are* attracted to it?" I asked, hedging.

Avery shrugged. "Maybe a little, but that was ten years ago. I like to think that I've outgrown guys like him."

I nodded. Made sense.

When Avery leaned into me, though, her face bright, her tongue darting playfully behind her white smile, I knew she had one last surprise. "If I were to have a fling with someone, it wouldn't be him."

My chest went tight. I tried to swallow, then failed. "Then who?"

"Mmm, wouldn't you like to know...."

About the Author

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at @kennywriter. I also operate eroticaformen.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.

Also by Kenny Wright

After School Special (A Short)

All In: Strip Poker Done Right

Because He's Watching; Ian's Obsession

Cool With Her

Dreaming of Another

Eight Hundred Dollar Heels (A Short)

Just Watch Me

Leap

Moving Mrs. Mitchell (A Short)

Naughty But Nice (A Short)

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The Woman She Was (A Short)

While She Watches

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